Cultural Determinants of Democracy and Dictatorship

Comparative Politics

October 18-22, 2021

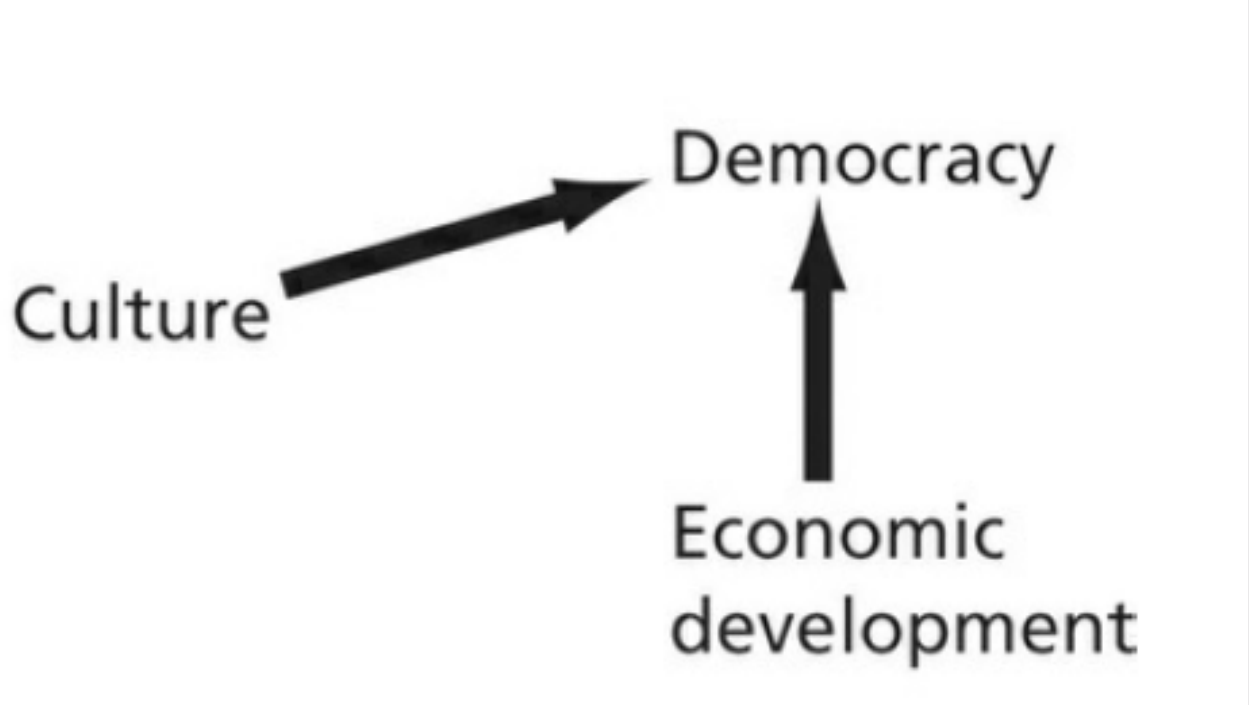
Last time

- We examined the proposition that **economic development** leads to **democracy**
- This is consistent with **modernization theory** or the **survival story**
- In assessing between the two theories, we stumbled upon some challenges in promoting democracy through development **(political resource curse, foreign aid)**
- What about non-economic factors?
- **This week:** The role of culture

What is the role of culture?

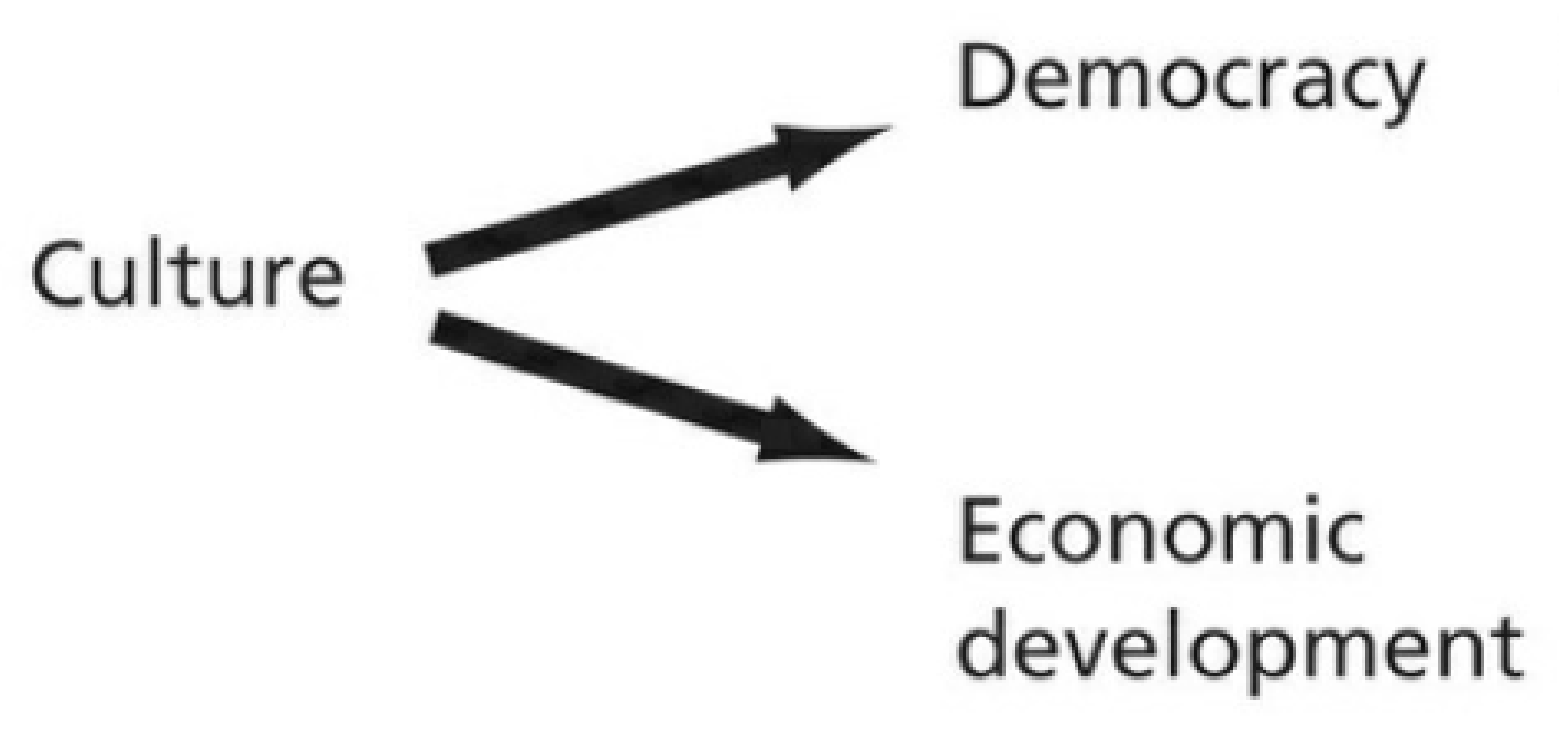
- We are adding an extra variable to the development $\rightarrow$ proposition
- Where does culture fit in?
- Is it an alternative to development? An intervening factor? Something else?
- We have many options

Paths to democracy



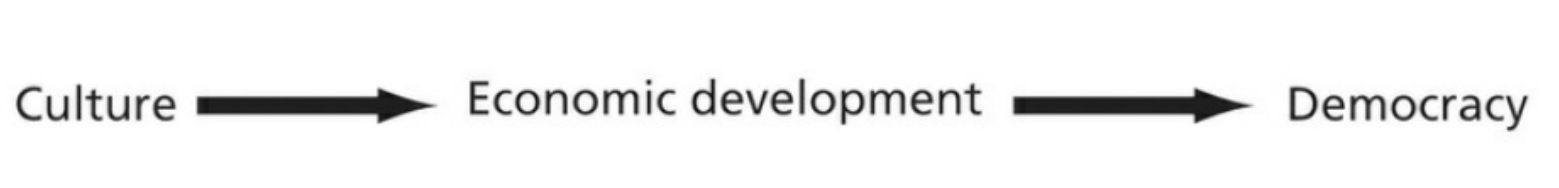
- Culture and development both **independently** lead to democracy

Paths to democracy



- Culture **leads to both** democracy and development

Paths to democracy

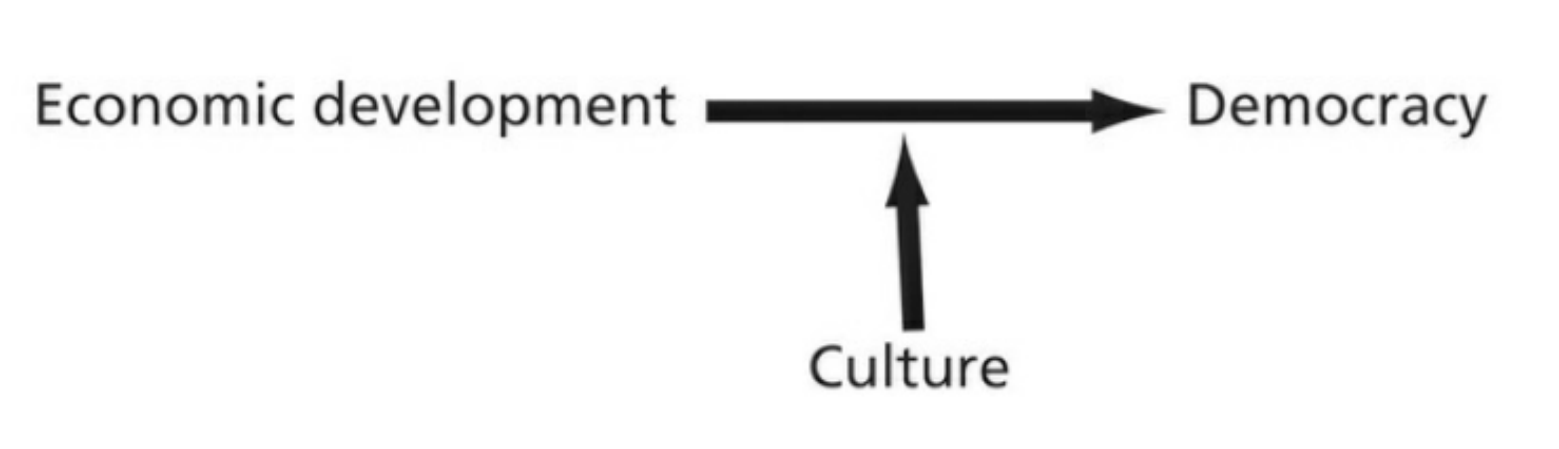


- Culture **facilitates** development, which in turn **leads to** democracy

Paths to democracy

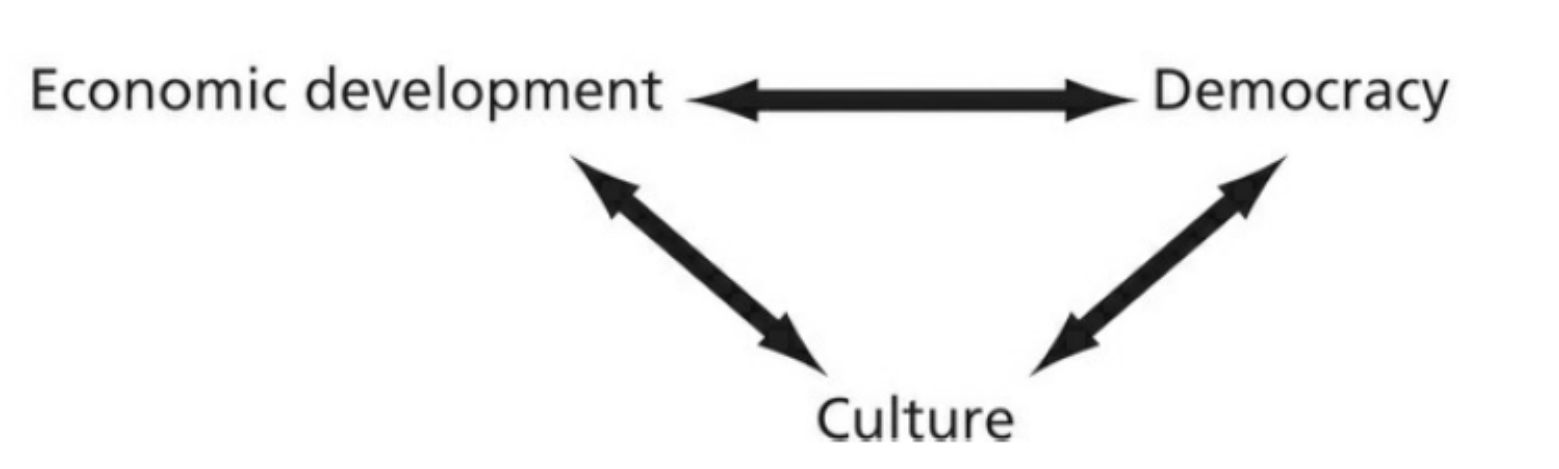
- Development **facilitates** culture, which in turn **leads to** democracy

Paths to democracy



- Development **leads to** democracy **only if** culture allows for it
- This is part of the **civic culture** argument discussed in **CGG**

Paths to democracy



- Culture, development, and democracy **all influence each other**
- This is the closest to reality, but also the least useful
- It does not inform policy nor illuminates our understanding of the world

Which makes more sense?

- That depends on what you believe about culture
- **Primordalist view:** Culture is fixed, objective, and inherited
- **Constructivist view:** Culture is invented and malleable
- The `primordialist` view believes some cultures are not compatible with democracy
- The `constructivist` view accepts that democracy needs a civic culture, but it can be promoted

What is culture?

culture Add to list Share

A *culture* is a specific group of people during a particular time — like the hippie culture of the 1960's. *Culture* can also imply exposure to the arts. Visit a museum if you are in need of a dose of *culture*.

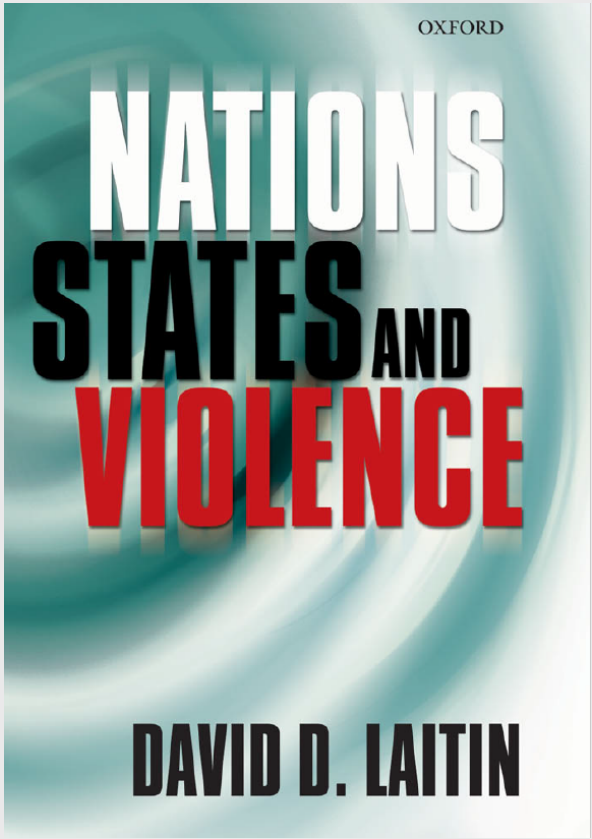
A useful thing to remember about *culture* is that it is closely related to *cultivate*, whose root meaning is "to till the soil." Even in Latin, the source language, *cultura* was used metaphorically (Cicero said philosophy was *cultura animi*, the "cultivation of the soul"), and in English it moved from the agricultural sense to training, development of language and literature, mental development through education, and finally the ideas, customs, and intellectual and artistic conditions of a society or group.

- Not very helpful 😠
- But political scientists usually interpret culture as **shared language, ethnicity, or religion**

Where does culture come from?

- Or, rather, why do we choose to emphasize different elements of culture across places and over time?
- **Example:**
  - In the US I am **hispanic/latino**
  - But in South America I am **mestizo**
- Some of that is my own decision, some of that is what society imposes on me

A mix of primordialism and constructivism



- We all have descriptive, objective culture
- But what we choose to emphasize is a function of personal and generational strategic interactions
- Individuals seek to be distinct enough to reap the benefits of being a member of a culture
- But not `too` distinct to be left alone

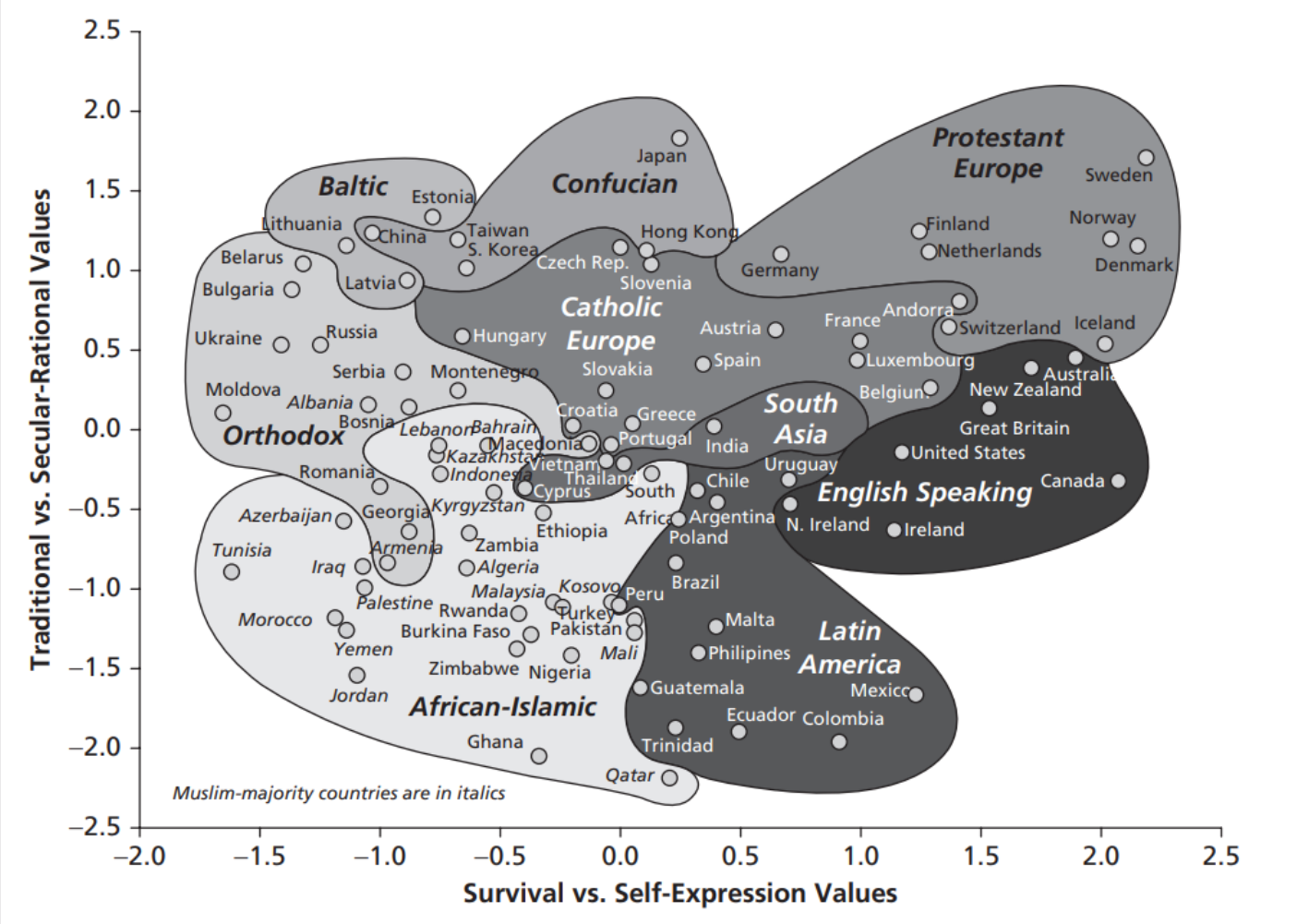
Cultural modernization theory

- Economic development does not directly cause democracy
- Instead, economic development produces certain cultural changes that lead to democracy
- Development creates a **civic culture** (Almond and Verba):
  - High interpersonal trust
  - Preference for gradual societal change
  - High support for existing political system
  - High levels of life satisfaction
- Countries with a civic culture are more likely to **become** and **stay** democratic

Cultural modernization theory

- Inglehart and Welzel propose an equally influential argument
- Two major sources of cultural variation in the world:
  - **Traditional** versus **secular** values
  - **Survival** versus **self-expression** values
- **Industrialization** development makes countries move `from traditional to secular` values
- **Post-industrialization** makes countries move `from survival to self-expression` values

A cultural map of the world



How to measure culture?

- Since Inglehart and Welzel started the `World Values Survey`, social scientist mostly use surveys to measure culture
- This is good, because we are asking people in different countries the same questions
- Yet it is hard, because people in different contexts may interpret and answer the same question differently
- Two challenges:

    1. ~~Social desirability bias~~ Sensitivity bias
    2. Differential item functioning

Sensitivity bias

- People lie in surveys because the question is sensitive

Democracy may have problems, but it's better than any other form of government. Could you please tell me if you strongly agree, agree, disagree, or strongly disagree?

- It feels like the question is asking you to like democracy!
- A participant who fears judgment or retaliation may say they agree even when they do not
- We can minimize sensitivity bias by asking indirect questions

Example 1: List experiment

Now I am going to read you three things that sometimes make people angry or upset. After I read them, tell me HOW MANY of them upset you. I don't want to know which ones, just HOW MANY.

Control

(1) The federal government increasing the tax on gasoline
(2) Professional athletes getting million-dollar salaries
(3) Large corporations polluting the environment

Treatment

(1) The federal government increasing the tax on gasoline
(2) Professional athletes getting million-dollar salaries
(3) Large corporations polluting the environment
(4) A black family moving next door

Example 2: Randomized response technique

For this question, I want you to answer yes or no. But I want you to consider the number of your dice throw. If it shows 1 on the dice, tell me no. If 6 shows, tell me yes. But if another number shows, tell me your own opinion about the question.

[TURN AWAY FROM RESPONDENT] Now throw the dice so that I cannot see what comes. Please do not forget the number that comes out.

Now, during the height of conflict in 2007 and 2008, did you know any militants, like a family member, a friend, or someone you talked to on a regular basis. Please, before your answer, take note of the number you rolled on the dice.

Indirect questions ensure anonimity

- **List experiment:**
  - The `difference between treatment and control` in the mean number of things that make people angry ranges from 0 to 1
  - We can interpret this as the proportion of the population that would get angry
- **Randomized response:**
  - We know that $1/6 \approx .17$ would say yes because of the dice
  - If 50% say yes in total, then $.5 - .17 = .33$ in the population know a militant
- In either case, we don't know who!

Differential item functioning (DIF)

- People in different countries interpret and answer questions differently
- Some of it comes from deep cultural differences
- But also just because people may be more or less accustomed to surveys `(e.g. weird to ask agree vs. strongly agree)`
- **Solution:** Anchoring vignettes

Example: Freedom of speech

Question: How free do you think [name/you] [is/are] to express [him-her/your]self without fear of government reprisal?

Options: Completely free, very free, moderately free, slightly free, not free at all

Vignettes:

1. [Kay] does not like many of the government's policies. She frequently publishes her opinion in newspapers, criticizing decisions by officials and calling for change. She sees little reason these actions could lead to government reprisal.

2. [Bob] has political views at odds with the government. He has heard of people occasionally being arrested for speaking out against the government, and government leaders sometimes make political speeches condemning those who criticize. He sometimes writes letters to newspapers about politics, but he is careful not to use his real name.

The role of religion

- **CGG** examine the role of religion as a recent focus in comparative politics
- Do not worry about the tables with stars

TABLE 7.2 **Cultural and Economic Determinants of Democratic Emergence**

Dependent variable: Probability that a country will be a democracy this year if it was a dictatorship last year

Independent Variables	Model 1	Model 2	Model 3	Model 4	Model 5
Muslim majority	−0.28**	−0.18	−0.23	−0.25	−0.18 ← Coefficient
	(0.12)	(0.16)	(0.17)	(0.19)	(0.16) ← Standard error
Protestant majority	−0.56	0.42	−0.40	0.45	−0.43
	(0.35)	(0.38)	(0.38)	(0.39)	(0.38)
Catholic majority	0.33***	0.31***	0.26**	0.26**	0.31**
	(0.10)	(0.12)	(0.12)	(0.13)	(0.13)
GDP per capita		0.00004*	0.00003*	0.00003*	0.00004*
		(0.00002)	(0.00002)	(0.00002)	(0.00002)
Growth in GDP per capita		−0.02**	−0.02**	−0.02**	−0.02**
		(0.01)	(0.01)	(0.01)	(0.01)
Oil production		0.15	−0.12	−0.13	−0.15
		(0.18)	(0.19)	(0.19)	(0.18)
Effective number of ethnic groups			−0.02		
			(0.02)		
Effective number of religious groups				−0.06	
				(0.09)	
Effective number of cultural groups					0.02
					(0.08)
Constant	−2.06***	−2.05***	−1.94***	−1.91***	−2.06***
	(0.07)	(0.10)	(0.13)	(0.23)	(0.19)
Number of observations	4,379	2,578	2,563	2,578	2,563
Log-likelihood	−418.75	−318.64	−317.85	−318.46	−318.35

*$p < 0.10$; **$p < 0.05$; ***$p < 0.01$

Note: Data on religious groups and whether a country is a democracy are from Przeworski and colleagues (2000), updated through 2000; data on GDP per capita and growth in GDP per capita are from the Penn World Tables 6.1 (2004; datacentre.chass.utoronto.ca/pwt61/); and data on ethnic and cultural groups are from Fearon (2003). The results shown in Table 7.2 come from a dynamic probit model. Standard errors are shown in parentheses.

IGNORE

The role of religion

- All you need to know is that Muslim majority countries seem to be less likely to transition to democracy from dictatorship, compared to Protestant and Catholic majority countries
- However, once we account for the effect of GDP per capita on development, the relationship disappears
- This is the basis of CGG's **fixed point in time** critique

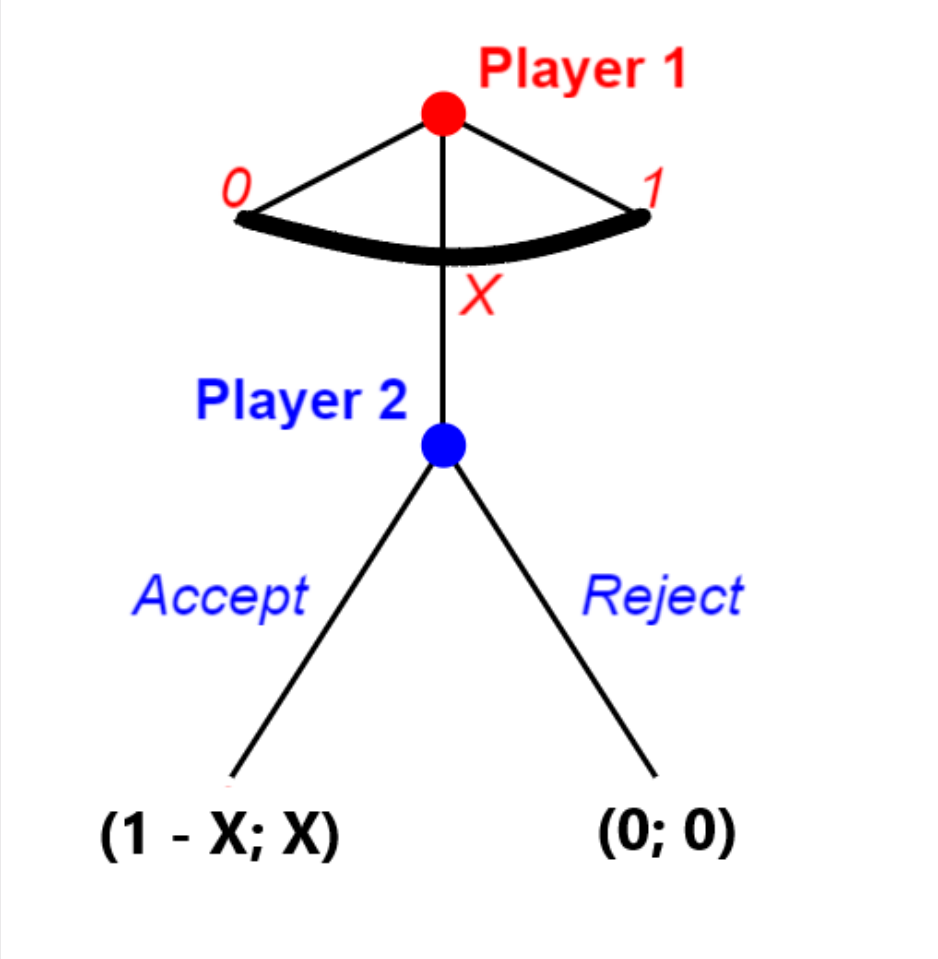
Fixed point in time critique

- Muslim culture seems more incompatible with democracy today
- But Catholicism seemed bad for democracy when few catholic countries were democracies
- **CGG** details how most religions have elements compatible and incompatible with democracy
- Today, Islam seems incompatible with democracy because few muslim countries are democracies
- We can say the same about economic development and democracy. Many rich countries are democracies now, but we can already see tension in this relationship

Using experiments to learn about culture

- We cannot do much about the **fixed point in time** problem. The world will change in unpredictable ways
- But we can look at the **micro-foundations** of the relationship with culture and democracy
- Behavioral economics use **experiments** that ask people to play **game theory** games to isolate the strategic elements of this relationship

Ultimatum game



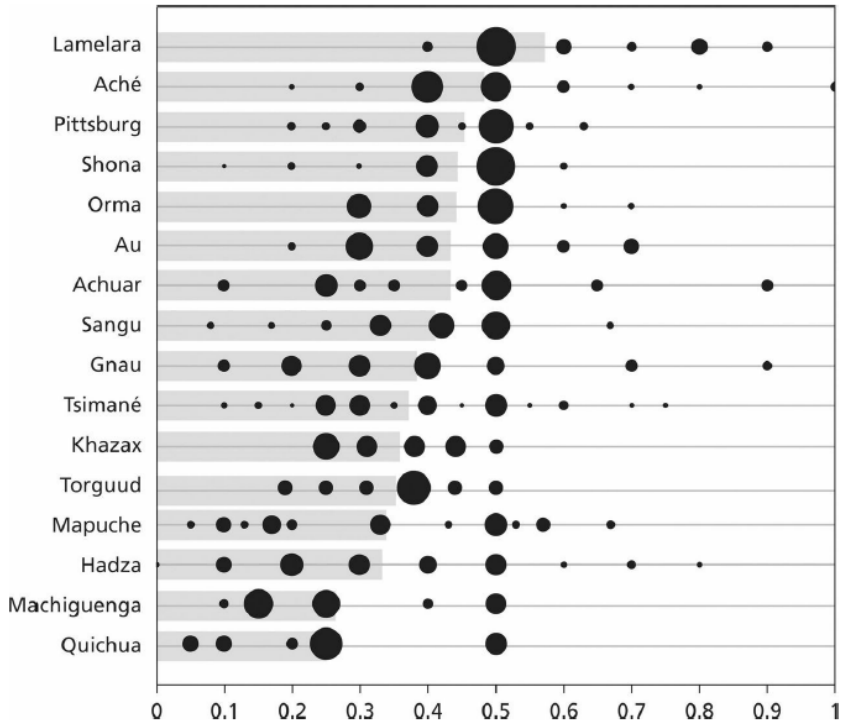
Applying the ultimatum game

- We cannot apply to mainstream cultures because they are already "contaminated" by the regime they live in
- Instead, focus on small scale societies with different economic activities

TABLE 7.4 **Fifteen Small-Scale Societies**

Group	Country	Environment	Economic base
Machiguenga	Peru	Tropical forest	Horticulture
Quichua	Ecuador	Tropical forest	Horticulture
Achuar	Ecuador	Tropical forest	Horticulture
Hadza	Tanzania	Savanna-woodlands	Foraging
Aché	Paraguay	Semi-tropical woodlands	Foraging and horticulture
Tsimané	Bolivia	Tropical forest	Horticulture
Au	Papua New Guinea	Mountainous tropical forest	Foraging and horticulture
Gnau	Papua New Guinea	Mountainous tropical forest	Foraging and horticulture
Mapuche	Chile	Temperate plains	Small-scale farming
Torguud	Mongolia	High-altitude desert, seasonally flooded grassland	Pastoralism
Khazax	Mongolia	High-altitude desert, seasonally flooded grassland	Pastoralism
Sangu (farm/herd)	Tanzania	Savanna-woodlands, seasonally flooded grassland	Agro-pastoralists
Orma	Kenya	Savanna-woodlands	Pastoralism
Lamelara	Indonesia	Tropical island coast	Foraging-trade
Shona	Zimbabwe	Savanna-woodlands	Farming

Ultimatum game in small scale societies



Note: The size of the bubble at each location along each row represents the proportion of the sample that made a particular offer. The right edge of the lightly shaded horizontal gray bar gives the mean offer for that group.

Source: Henrich and colleagues (2005).

What does this mean for Culture $\rightarrow$ Democracy?

- People played according to the expectations of their culture
- **Culture** is a **shared way to play games** that evolved over generations
- Not too different from **formal institutions**
- Shared culture can facilitate or complicate the ways in which democracy requires people to coordinate
- But this is by no means dooming, both cultures and institutions can **adapt**
- The important part is that adaptation is both **smoother** and **desirable** when cultures expect to benefit from democracy

Takeaways

- Culture may affect democracy in many ways, sometimes in interplay with economic development
- Cultural modernization theory suggests that economic development creates a civic culture favorable for democracy
- We evaluate this theory with surveys, but surveys bring challenges of their own
- Beyond surveys, we tend to focus on the role of religion, but the problem is that we can only analyze it at a fixed point in time
- A solution is to use abstract behavioral economics experiments. From them we learn that a compatible culture can favor transition to democracy, but also that societies will adapt whenever it is in their best interest to do so

Reminder:

Quiz 2 Due Friday 5:00 PM

Next Week:

Democratic Transitions